



Hitting the bulls eye: Rhythm Sangwan secured a 16th shooter quota for India at the 2024 Paris Olympics by winning a bronze medal in 25m sports pistol at the Asia Olympic Qualifiers in January. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

skeet have qualification and finals on two different days. Originally, only rapid-fire pistol, sports pistol, trap and skeet events were spread over two days. The air pistol and air rifle individual events had qualification and finals on the same day in the past. The shooters have time to channel their energy and be at their best in their bid to win medals this time. Equally, it may be that much more difficult to grab medals.

Realigning our focus on the quota places, it has to be noted that the Indian rifle shooters swept all eight possible Olympic quota places before the pistol and shotgun shooters. **The pistol shooters have grabbed seven of the eight possible quota places, with only the women's second air pistol quota left to be won.**

As we know, a country can win only a maximum of two Olympic quota places in an event. The ISSF made it harder for the shooters by introducing a new rule that a country can win only one quota per event in a qualification championship in the current Olympic cycle.

In trap and skeet, India has one Olympic quota each in the four events for men and women and can aspire to win one more in each of the four events.

It's ironic that the Olympic trials for shotgun shooting, meant to determine the athletes representing the country, concluded before the announcement of selected shooters. This situation is akin to putting the cart before the horse!

If India fails to secure all available Olympic quota places in shotgun, this could be a contributing factor, despite the absence of official announcements regarding selected shooters. Some experienced shooters have expressed concerns about competitors not giving their best to secure Olympic quotas if they know they won't be considered for the Paris Games.

From a general perspective, the quota winner rightfully deserves the opportunity to compete in the Games unless their performance drastically declines or another shooter consistently outperforms them on the international stage.

There was consideration for deciding the rifle squad for the Games in advance to alleviate suspense and allow shooters to prepare adequately. However, the national federation opted to conduct the rifle and pistol Olympic trials

concurrently.

Abhinav spoke with the High-Performance Director (HPD), Dr. Pierre Beauchamp, who has put a system in place.

"My only advice to the HPD was that the trials could be very tiring and quite draining. The athletes need enough time to recover from it, recharge, and go into the Games fresh. It is an important element," Abhinav said.

The world and Olympic champion, Abhinav, was also clear that the rifle shooters may not benefit from an early set of trials exclusively for them.

"The only guarantee in sports is that there is no guarantee! Give everyone a fair chance to gain their spots through the trials and have enough time to prepare and be at their best in the Games", said Abhinav.

Is it fair to only consider the best three scores out of four from domestic trials to select the team for the Olympics? Why can't we have a special status for a world champion like Rudranksh Patil, or for that matter, Mehuli Ghosh, who won the quota with a World Championship silver medal?

Even when Abhinav was the reigning World Champion in the run-up to the 2008 Olympics, the federation authorities were considering the idea of putting the Asian champion for the Games based on current form. Luckily, they didn't do this, and Abhinav went on to win the Olympic gold in Beijing. As the World Champion, Abhinav kept a low profile in the international arena, sharpening his skills and mastery of air rifle so he could peak at the right time and succeed in Beijing.

"The parameters keep changing. It is impossible to build a perfect plan. Despite the talent of Indian shooting, it is impossible to build a plan. In the past, it was ideal, as the difference between the first and the rest was massive. Or, after 1 and 2, the difference was huge. Fewer people had the chance to win a medal. It is impossible to follow the same method now as in the past," opined Abhinav.

Apart from being a shooter who